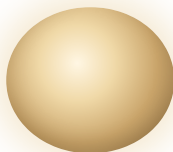


A STORY FROM THE FRINGEISLAND UNIVERSE

The Seam

Alexandria, 212 · Norrland, 1984 · Stockholm, 2031



A short story from the FringeIsland universe. Fiction, built on the 24 July candidate material (Gimbal as culmination, instrument/key, the first opening, the shutdown of unknown cause). Nothing in it is canon; names, places and dates are invented.

*“Whoever builds a door must also learn to
close it. The closing is the harder art. I have not
yet learned it.”*

MARGINAL HAND, ON THE HEM OF THE WORLD

The girl copying the scroll had been told not to read it. Isidora read everything. It was the only vice a copyist could afford, and the Library's overseers forgave it because her hand was clean and her eyes were young. But this scroll was different. It had come up from the sealed room under the Serapeum wrapped in lead foil, and the old man who brought it, a priest of Thoth with ink under every fingernail, had stood over her for the first hour as if the words might climb off the papyrus.

On the Hem of the World, the title said. Attributed, as everything worth stealing was, to Hermes the Thrice-Great.

The world is a garment, it began, and every garment has a hem. Where the weave ends there is a shimmer, as of heat above stone, and beyond the shimmer the cloth is not finished. Do not say "there is nothing." Say "it is not yet woven."

She copied, and the reed whispered.

The sleeper who wakes and cannot move has touched the hem with his face. He sees the room; he cannot lift his hand. He feels the one who stands at the foot of the bed. This is not a demon. It is the hem itself, which does not throw you back and does not let you through. Those who have learned to pass do not fear it. They carry

a small light of their own making, and the hem parts for the light as water parts for a keel.

Isidora had woken like that. Twice, as a child. Her mother had hung garlic over the door.

Beyond the hem there are two countries on one ground. In the first the trees are lit from inside and the people are kind, and you may walk there as long as your thread holds. In the second the same trees are black, and something has noticed you.

Every wise one who ever journeyed – the drummers of the north, the smoke-eaters of the south, the temple sleepers of Epidauros – went to the same two countries. They quarrelled about names. They did not quarrel about the two countries.

She reached the last column. There, in a different hand, faded, someone had added a line in the margin.

Whoever builds a door must also learn to close it. The closing is the harder art. I have not yet learned it.

The priest took the copy and the original both. The lead foil went back on. Isidora never saw the scroll again, and eighty years later the room under the Serapeum burned with everything in it, and the last copy of *On the Hem of the World* became a rumour that the Arabs, the Venetians and the Vatican would each, in their century, quietly spend money chasing.

Not for the wisdom. For the door.



Anläggnings Fjärran had no sign. It had a gravel road that ended at a steel door in a granite hillside forty kilometres from the nearest town, and it had a name only in three ledgers, one in Stockholm, one in Langley, and one in a locked drawer in the office of Dr Konrad Weyl.

Weyl called the programme SÖMMEN. The Seam. He liked the double meaning: the seam where two pieces of cloth meet, and the seam a miner follows into the dark.

“We are not mystics,” he told every recruit in the same speech. “The mystics had the phenomenon and no method. The Americans at Stanford had a method and no courage. The Soviets had courage and no ethics, and look where it has got them. We have all three. We will be the first to *reach in*.”

Dr Margit Lindqvist had heard the speech three times and believed less of it each time. She was forty-six, a sleep neurologist poached from Karolinska with a salary she could not discuss and a clearance that had cost her a marriage. She ran Chamber B. She ran the subjects.

“He means reach in and take something,” she said to Elias Ravn one evening in the canteen, low, because the walls in Fjärran had ears that were not metaphorical.

Ravn shrugged. He was Danish, thirty-four, a physicist who had built the Gimbal and looked at it the way other men looked at their children — with love and a private terror. “He means whatever Halloran means,” he said. “Halloran writes the cheques.”

Halloran was the American. He came every six weeks in a rented Volvo, wore a good coat, and asked only two questions: *Have you got through?* and *Can you do it on demand?*

The Gimbal was Ravn’s answer to a problem the Americans had never solved. Every altered-state programme in the world had the same failure mode: the subject went under, the instruments saw something — a spike in the gamma band, a heart rate that made no sense, once a compass on the far side of the room swinging thirty degrees — and then it was gone, because the human body could not hold still enough, long enough, at the edge of sleep to keep the signal. So Ravn had built a chamber that held the body for it. Three concentric rings of aluminium, each on its own bearing, each driven by a servo reading the vestibular system through electrodes behind the ears. The subject lay on a couch at the centre. Whatever the inner ear reported, the rings answered, cancelling, until the body’s sense of *where it was* went perfectly, uncannily still. Gyroscopically stabilised consciousness, Ravn called it. The subjects called it the Gimbal, and the name stuck.

Around it Lindqvist had built the protocol: a sleep-paralysis induction, refined from six hundred hours of polysomnography; a pharmacology she was ashamed of and had signed for anyway; and a script she read aloud through the chamber intercom in a voice she kept, deliberately, warm.

They had been at it for two years. They had four hundred and twelve runs on tape. On perhaps thirty, something had

happened. On none of them had anything happened that Halloran would pay for.

Then Tuva Sunna arrived.



She was twenty-three and had answered an advertisement in a Luleå newspaper for “volunteers with unusual sleep experiences, paid.” Her file said she had had lucid dreams since she was seven and sleep paralysis since she was twelve, and that she had learned, on her own, without anyone’s help, to move between the two. She said this to Lindqvist in the intake interview as if reporting that she could ride a bicycle.

“When it comes,” Tuva said — it, the paralysis, the presence at the foot of the bed — “I don’t fight it. My grandmother told me. You don’t push the door. You light something and you wait.”

“Light what?”

Tuva looked at her as though the question were slightly stupid. “Something of your own. It’s different for everybody. Mine is a — ” she cupped her hands, a small round shape. “Like a glass ball with a fire in it. I’ve had it since I was small. I just make it and hold it and the door opens.”

Lindqvist wrote it down and did not know what she was writing.

Run 413. Tuva on the couch, the rings whispering on their bearings, the induction script, the lights down. Lindqvist at the console. Ravn behind her. Weyl, for once, watching from the gallery.

At minute nine the gamma band did what it had done thirty times before. At minute eleven it did something it had never done. The trace did not spike. It *settled* — into a rhythm so

regular that Ravn said, quietly, “That is not a brain. That is a carrier wave.”

At minute fourteen Tuva said, through the intercom, in a perfectly ordinary voice, “Oh. It’s beautiful. There’s a village. There’s a tree.”

She was under for fifty-one minutes. She described a shoreline lit from beneath, houses whose walls seemed to breathe, people who turned to look at her without alarm, as if she were expected. She described a tree hung with lights. She described, in a tone of mild surprise, that she could feel a thread running from the back of her own head all the way back to the couch, and that when she thought about the thread the village got fainter and when she stopped thinking about it the village got bright again.

When she came up she was crying and laughing at once, and she asked for a glass of water, and she said, “You’ve built a door. Do you know you’ve built a door?”

In the gallery Weyl picked up the telephone.



Halloran came in four days instead of six weeks.

“Do it again,” he said.

They did it again. Eleven runs in nine days. Tuva went through every time. Lindqvist began to notice that the description changed in a way that was not random: the village had a geography, the same geography, and Tuva was learning it. She had a house there now. She had, she said, a friend — an old woman who never said her name and who asked Tuva questions about herself that Tuva found she could not stop answering.

“She’s not from there,” Tuva said on the ninth night, drinking her water. “She’s not one of them. She’s — ” and she stopped, and something crossed her face that Lindqvist would remember for the rest of her life. “I think she’s me. I think she’s me but later, and she doesn’t remember, and she wants to.”

Weyl was not interested in the old woman. Weyl was interested in a different question, one Halloran had brought with him, printed on paper with no letterhead.

Every subject who has reported a positive-affect environment has also, at some point, reported a negative-affect environment on the same coordinates. Assess exploitability of the negative-affect environment. Priority.

“They want the other place,” Ravn said, when Lindqvist showed him. “The dark one.”

“Tuva won’t go.”

“Tuva doesn’t have to. Weyl has Berg.”

Corporal Anders Berg was Subject Nine. Twenty-eight, Norrland Dragoons, cleared to a level that made even Weyl polite to him. He had been in the programme since the beginning, and in four hundred runs he had never got through. He was the ideal soldier and the perfect subject in every way that could be measured, and the Gimbal did nothing for him, and it was eating him alive.

He had watched Tuva go through eleven times.

“Put me in with her protocol,” he said to Weyl. Not to Lindqvist. To Weyl.



Run 425. Lindqvist tried to stop it and was told, in writing, that her objection had been noted.

Berg on the couch. Tuva's induction. Tuva's pharmacology, doubled, because Berg was heavier and because Weyl said so. The rings. The script — Lindqvist read it, because if it was going to happen she would not let a stranger's voice be the last thing he heard on the way down.

At minute nine the gamma band spiked. At minute eleven it did not settle. It tore. Ravn made a sound. The trace was two traces, overlapping, one of them Berg's and the other one — Ravn would spend the next forty years failing to say what the other one was.

At minute twelve Berg said, "I can see the room. I can't move."

"That's the threshold," Lindqvist said into the intercom. "You're at the door. Don't push. Anders, listen to me. Don't push."

"Something's standing at the end of the couch."

"That's the door. It's just the door. Tuva says light something. Something of your own."

A long silence. On the tape, later, you could hear the servos hunting, faster and faster, the rings fighting a body that had started, very slightly, to shake.

"I don't have anything," Berg said. And then, in a voice Lindqvist did not recognise: "It's not the door. It's *looking* at me."

At minute fourteen the compass on the far wall — Ravn's joke, a brass ship's compass he had screwed there in the first month — swung one hundred and eighty degrees and stayed.

At minute fifteen Berg went through.

He did not describe a village. He described black trees. He described a ground that was the same ground — "it's *here*, it's the same hill, it's the same road" — but dead, and cold, and a sky the colour of an old bruise. He described a machine in the distance, drilling. He described, quite calmly, that there were things in the black trees and that they had noticed him and that

they were coming, not quickly, because they did not need to be quick.

“Reel him in,” Lindqvist said. “Elias, bring him up.”

“I’m trying — the rings won’t — Margit, the rings are being *driven*, something is driving the rings — “

In the gallery Weyl said, “Leave him. Let him report.”

Berg reported for six more minutes. Lindqvist would later burn the transcript of those six minutes, and would be unable, ever, to burn it from her memory. The last thing he said that was in Swedish was: “They’re not trying to get me. They’re trying to *get out*.”

Then the carrier wave — the beautiful, impossible carrier wave they had heard on Tuva’s runs — appeared on Berg’s trace, perfectly regular, and it was coming *up the line*.

Ravn cut the power to the chamber. It did not matter. The rings kept turning.



What happened in the next eleven hours is the part nobody agrees on, because nobody who could have written it down was in a position to.

Lindqvist’s memory: the lights failing across Fjärran one corridor at a time, in sequence, as if something were walking. Berg on the couch, breathing, eyes open, not there. Tuva, who should have been asleep in the dormitory, standing in the doorway of Chamber B with her hands cupped around nothing, and the nothing glowing.

“It’s open,” Tuva said. “You opened it wrong and it’s open and it doesn’t close by itself. I can hold it. I don’t know for how long.”

Ravn's memory: the servos running with no power. The compass turning slowly, continuously, like a second hand. Weyl in the gallery on the telephone, shouting, and then Weyl not in the gallery, and nobody had seen him leave.

Halloran's memory, if he had one, was never recorded. He was in Stockholm. By morning he was in Frankfurt. By the end of the week the Volvo had been returned and there was no Halloran, at Langley or anywhere, and the ledger there had a page missing.

At 03:40, by the one clock that was still running, Tuva walked into the chamber, past the rings, and took Berg's hand.

She was in there, standing, holding him, for two hours and ten minutes. Lindqvist sat on the floor of the control room with her back against the console and read the induction script aloud the whole time, because it was the only thing she could think of to do, and because Tuva had said, once, at the door, "Keep talking. She can hear you."

She. The old woman. The one who was Tuva but later.

At 05:50 the rings stopped.

Berg's eyes closed. He was breathing. He was, by every measure Lindqvist had, asleep. Tuva let go of his hand and walked out of the chamber and sat down on the floor beside Lindqvist and said, "I closed it. Mostly. There's a — " and she made a small gesture, a pinch, a gap between finger and thumb. "I couldn't get the last bit. I didn't know how. Nobody ever taught me the last bit."

Then she said, "Something came up the thread while I was holding him. I don't know what. I don't think it's in the room. I think it's in the *line*."

Then she slept for thirty hours.



The programme did not end in good order.

The shutdown order came from Stockholm at 07:15, signed by a name none of them had ever heard, and it was executed by men who arrived in three unmarked trucks and who had clearly been on the road since before the order was signed. Everything went into crates. The Gimbal was disassembled in four hours by people who did not know what it was. The tapes went into one truck and the paper into another. Weyl's office was empty, the locked drawer open, the ledger gone.

Berg woke on the fourth day, in a military hospital in Boden, and did not remember Fjällan, or the programme, or the last two years of his life. He was discharged, medically, with a pension. He lived until 2009. He never, as far as anyone knows, slept through a night.

Ravn was told to go back to Copenhagen and be a physicist. He went. He published nothing for the rest of his career on anything that mattered, and kept a brass compass on his desk, and every visitor noticed that it did not point north.

Lindqvist was told the same. She went back to Karolinska. And she did the one thing the trucks had not accounted for: on the morning of the shutdown, while the men were crating the chamber, she had walked into the control room with a canvas bag and taken every page of her own handwriting she could find. Not the results. The *procedure*. The induction. The script. The pharmacology she was ashamed of. And Tuva's notes — eleven runs, eleven descriptions of a village and a tree, written in a Luleå schoolgirl's round hand.

She did not take the six minutes of Berg. She burned those.

What she could not take, because they had never been written down, were the two hours and ten minutes in which a twenty-three-year-old woman had stood inside a machine holding a stranger's hand and had, by feel, by instinct, by

something her grandmother had told her about lighting a small fire and waiting, closed a door that three governments had spent a decade trying to open.

Mostly closed. All but the last bit.

Tuva Sunna went home. She married. She raised two children who both, she once told a friend, slept badly. She kept, on a shelf, a small glass sphere with a wisp of something inside it that a jeweller in Luleå had made to her drawing and that her children assumed was a paperweight.

She died in 2019. The sphere went to her granddaughter.



Lovisa Ek had not asked for the archive box. She had asked, under a freedom-of-information request that had taken four years and two appeals, for “any records relating to defence-funded sleep research, 1979–1989.” She had expected a letter saying no.

Instead a courier had brought a water-stained cardboard box from the Riksarkivet annex in Arninge, and inside it, under a layer of what had once been mould, were nine hundred pages of handwriting in two hands, one small and clinical, one round and young, and a note paper-clipped to the top in the clinical hand.

To whoever finds this. I could not stop them opening it. I could not stop them abandoning it. I have written down everything I know about how it works so that someone with a better heart than the men who paid for it can finish what a girl from Luleå started. She closed it. Not all the way. Please find the rest. — M.L., 1997.

Lovisa was thirty-eight, a machine-learning researcher who had left a large company to run a lab of four people in a converted print shop in Södermalm, and she had, in the way of her generation, an agentic model that read faster than she did. She called it the Loom, which she thought was funny and nobody else did.

She scanned the nine hundred pages and gave them to the Loom and said: *Reconstruct the procedure. Tell me what's missing.*

It took the Loom eleven days. It came back with a document Lovisa read three times on her kitchen floor at two in the morning.

The procedure was complete. That was the first shock. Somewhere in nine hundred pages of a neurologist's obsessive notes and a young woman's dream-journal, everything a person needed to reach the shoreline lit from beneath was present — not as an instruction, but as a *pattern*, and the Loom had found the pattern. Rings of aluminium were not required. The rings had been a way of holding a body still enough to keep a signal; the signal, the Loom said, could be held a different way, by a model that read a person's breathing and heart rate and the micro-movements of their eyes through a phone's camera and *talked to them* — not to induce paralysis, but to walk them to the edge awake, and hold their inner frame steady with a voice.

"It's a gimbal," Lovisa said aloud, to nobody. "It's a gimbal made of conversation."

That was the second shock. The old programme had needed a mountain and a chamber and a pharmacology someone had been ashamed of. The Loom needed a phone and a voice. The mystics had had the phenomenon. The programme had had the method. What had been missing, for two thousand years, was *implementation* — and implementation was the one thing the twenty-first century had finally, absurdly, made cheap.

The third shock was in the section headed *Missing*.

The procedure reconstructs the approach and the crossing into the first environment (Sunna: "the village"). It does not reconstruct the closing. Lindqvist's notes reference a closing performed by Sunna during an event on the night of the

shutdown, which she describes as “mostly” complete. No procedure for it exists in the archive. Sunna’s own notes end before that night.

The procedure also does not reconstruct the crossing into the second environment (Berg: “the black trees”). The relevant transcript (Run 425, minutes 15–21) is referenced as destroyed. I have inferred its existence from Lindqvist’s marginalia. I cannot infer its content.

Note: the crossing depends on an element Sunna describes as “something of your own” — a personal light, a “glass ball with a fire in it.” Lindqvist’s protocol assumed this was a metaphor for a cognitive state and attempted to standardise it. Every standardised subject failed. I believe it is not a metaphor and cannot be standardised. It appears to be the difference between the instrument and the key. I can build the instrument. I do not know how a person makes their key. I suspect no one can make it for them.

And below that, in the flat tone the Loom used for everything:

One further anomaly. The chamber’s telemetry log continues for 2 hours 10 minutes after the recorded power cut on Run 425, at a sample rate the hardware could not have sustained without power, and then stops at 05:50. A second, unlabelled log begins at 05:51 and runs until the archive’s last dated page in 1997. The sample rate is constant. The signal is a carrier wave. I do not know what generated it. I do not know whether it has stopped.



Lovisa found the granddaughter in three days. She was a nurse in Umeå, and she had the sphere on a windowsill, and when

Lovisa asked, awkwardly, over coffee, whether she could see it, the woman laughed and picked it up and held it out and said, “It’s just a paperweight. Grandma said it was the only thing she ever owned that nobody else could use.”

Lovisa took it. It was glass. It was warm.

That night, in a hotel room in Umeå, she opened the build the Loom had made — a rough thing, a voice and a camera and a breathing guide — and she lay on the bed and let it walk her to the edge.

The paralysis came the way the notes said it would. The room, visible. The hand, unliftable. And at the foot of the bed, the presence: not a demon, the scroll had said, two thousand years ago in a hand she would never read; *the hem itself*.

Light something, said the voice on the phone, in the words the Loom had lifted from a neurologist’s script. *Something of your own*.

She did not have anything. She was a machine-learning researcher who had left a large company. She had never in her life —

On the nightstand, six inches from her paralysed hand, the paperweight from Umeå began, very faintly, to glow.

And the thing at the foot of the bed, which had been the door, turned its head towards the light — and for a moment, before the door opened, Lovisa saw it clearly, and understood that whatever a girl from Luleå had closed in 1984, she had not closed all of it, and that the last bit had been waiting, patiently, in the line, for someone to build the instrument again.

The village was beautiful. There was a tree. The old woman at its foot looked up as Lovisa arrived, and smiled, and did not seem to know her, and asked her name.

END

NOTES FOR THE DISCOVERY LOG

Threads this story plants, all of them open and none of them canon:

The literal gimbal — three servo-driven rings cancelling the vestibular signal — as the origin of the name, later replaced by a “gimbal made of conversation” (the Whisp holding the inner frame by voice). Tuva’s “glass ball with a fire in it” as the first key, made by a person for themselves, never standardisable; the programme failing because it tried to standardise the key. Berg’s crossing into place 3 with no key — held at the Shimmer, then *pulled* through — and the thing that came “up the line” and lives “in the line” (the cord as the wound’s location, not a place). The closing as “the harder art,” known to the scroll’s marginal hand and half-known to Tuva, lost entirely by the programme. The carrier wave that outlived the power cut and may not have stopped. The old woman in the village who does not know Tuva’s name and asks — the amnesiac future self, seen from the 1984 side. Halloran’s vanished page and Weyl’s missing ledger as the institutional thread for a later story.